Q4-quality, 8k-prefill INT4 inference for Ossicle-4B on RDNA3

Rotated GPTQ weights, 8-bit and 4-bit activations on WMMA, and what it cost

A technical report on the full run: methods, measurements, failures

Work log compiled from the session logs, scripts and commits

1 November 2026

Abstract

We take the Ossicle-4B audio–language model (Qwen3.5-4B backbone, Qwen3-Omni AuT audio encoder), convert it to GGUF for llama.cpp, quantise it in ten standard formats, and then build a custom prefill/decode path for a single AMD RX 7900 XT (RDNA3, `gfx1100`) that stores every linear weight *Hadamard-rotated*, *GPTQ-quantised* to symmetric int4, and multiplies it on the int4 WMMA units against rotated 8-bit or 4-bit activations. The shipped file (2.55 GB, one copy of the weights in VRAM: 3.36 GB peak) reaches **7,109 tokens/s prefill at pp512 (6,996 at pp2048) at KLD 0.025 against BF16, with decode at 174 tokens/s**, i.e. better agreement with BF16 than Q4_K_M (KLD 0.030–0.032) at 50% faster prefill and 32% faster decode. A one-variable preset, `GGML_INT4_PREFILL=fast`, raises prefill to **10,932 tokens/s (pp2048: 10,599)** at KLD 0.101 (Q3_K_L class by KLD, MMAU unchanged within noise). Multi-token-prediction speculative decoding on top of this reaches **232 tokens/s** (+38%, output identical to plain decoding), and the same recipe applied to the stock Qwen3.5-4B gives the same quality and speed. We document every experiment, including the ones that failed (FP4 re-gridding, sparsity skipping, wider weight scale groups, the 256-wide WMMA attention kernel shipped upstream) and the caveats that remain.

Headline (RX 7900 XT, ROCm 10.1.0)	pp512	pp2048	tg128	KLD	same top-1	MMAU
Q4_K_M (best stock Q4, reference)	4,733	4,595	131.6	0.032	91%	72.2
rotated INT4, `quality` (default)	7,109	6,996	174	0.025	92.3%	71.7
rotated INT4, `balanced`	9,398	9,109	174	0.070	88.1%	–
rotated INT4, `fast`	**10,932**	**10,599**	174	0.101	85.0%	71.8
`quality` + MTP (2 drafts, `llama-server`)	–		**232**	0.025	–	–

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1 Goal, hardware and model

The work proceeded in a sequence of requests, each building on the last:

1. Convert the BF16 Ossicle-4B checkpoint to GGUF; quantise it in the usual llama.cpp formats; measure quality (perplexity, KL divergence, MMAU) and speed on an RX 7900 XT and an RTX 5060 Ti; push the result to a private HF repository.
2. Fix the audio front end of llama.cpp so GGUF accuracy matches PyTorch (opt-in GGUF keys), and move AMD to ROCm 10.1.
3. Use the 7900 XT's int4 matrix instructions for a faster prefill (a "W4A4" path).
4. *"Get decode up and reduce KL vs BF16. Get it to Q4 quality."*
5. *"Get me 8k prefill with this decode."*

Items 4 and 5 are the focus of this report; items 1–3 are summarised (Sections 2–4) because the later work depends on them.

Hardware and software. GPU: AMD Radeon RX 7900 XT (gfx1100, wave32, 20 GB, 254 W power cap, sustained clock ≈2.28 GHz). Second GPU for cross-checking the standard quants: NVIDIA RTX 5060 Ti 16 GB (CUDA 13.0). ROCm 10.1.0 from the pip wheels (isolated venv; ROCm 7.2.0 kept for comparison). llama.cpp fork `SILVERTHRONE32/llama.cpp-ossicle`, branch `ossicle`, based on upstream `f2b52a87e`; current head `1fcc55e87`.

Model. The language model is Qwen3.5-4B (merged LoRA), 4.21 B parameters: 32 layers, hidden size 2560, FFN width 9216, vocabulary 248,320 with tied embedding/head (1.27 GB in BF16). Layers alternate three *gated-delta-net* (GDN, linear-attention) layers with one full-attention layer (24 GDN + 8 attention). GDN uses 16 key heads, 32 value heads, head dimension 128 and a 4-wide causal convolution; full attention uses 16 query heads, 4 KV heads, head dimension 256. The 200 quantised linear tensors are, per layer kind: GDN `attn_qkv`, `attn_gate` (the z-gate), `ssm_out`; attention `attn_q`, `attn_k`, `attn_v`, `attn_output`; and in every layer `ffn_gate`, `ffn_up`, `ffn_down` ($24\times3 + 8\times4 + 32\times3 = 200$).

Metrics.

- **KLD / same-top-1**: `llama-perplexity --kl-divergence` against logits of the BF16 GGUF on WikiText-2 test, context 512, 24 chunks (≈12k tokens). Standard error is about ±0.001 near KLD 0.025 and ±0.003 near 0.1.
- **PPL**: WikiText-2 test, full set (standard quants) or the same 24 chunks (INT4 variants; stated as "vs BF16").
- **MMAU**: test-mini, 1000 questions, greedy decoding through `llama-server`, string-match scorer; standard error ±1.4 pp, so differences under ∼3 pp are noise. PyTorch BF16 scores 72.1.
- **Speed**: `llama-bench`. For the INT4 work we use the *median of 8 runs after discarding the first* (`scripts/bench_med.sh`: `-r 9`, first sample dropped), because the first sample is taken at cold GPU clocks and wrecks short means (e.g. one 3-run bench logged pp512 4810 ± 1416 against a steady 5,846).

2 Baseline: GGUF conversion and the standard quant ladder

The BF16 safetensors were converted with llama.cpp's `qwen35` text architecture and `qwen3a` mmproj (`scripts/convert_ossicle.py`); the chat template is patched to always emit an empty `<think>` block, which is how Ossicle was trained. Ten quants were produced with an importance matrix from WikiText-2 train (Q8_0 without) and each was measured on both GPUs. Table 1 is the quality table, Table 2 the speed table.

Table 1: Standard quants of Ossicle-4B. PPL: WikiText-2 test. MMAU: patched llama.cpp (audio fix of Section 3).

Quant	GB	PPL	KLD	top-1 %	MMAU XT	MMAU Ti	MMAU stock
BF16 (ref)	8.42	10.571	–	–	71.8	71.8	70.2
Q8_0	4.48	10.566	0.0023	97.9	72.3	72.1	70.5
Q6_K	3.46	10.670	0.0063	95.6	72.3	72.4	70.5
Q5_K_M	3.08	10.740	0.0146	94.0	72.8	72.2	71.2
Q4_K_M	2.71	10.951	0.0303	91.1	72.1	72.4	70.0
Q4_K_S	2.56	10.939	0.0346	90.8	72.0	71.9	70.8
Q4_0	2.55	10.994	0.0581	89.2	71.9	71.7	70.8
IQ4_XS	2.51	10.884	0.0346	90.9	72.0	71.4	70.9
Q3_K_L	2.42	11.681	0.1011	85.5	70.3	70.2	69.4
Q3_K_M	2.26	11.820	0.1077	85.0	70.6	70.7	70.5
Q3_K_S	2.07	12.203	0.1492	82.5	69.6	69.9	69.3

Table 2: Speed of the standard quants (first-token = full `llama-server` path with one 10 s clip; XT = 7900 XT/ROCm 10.1, Ti = 5060 Ti/CUDA 13.0). These use a different method from the INT4 tables (server median of 5), hence Q4_K_M pp512 of 4,482 here against 4,733 in the INT4 comparisons.

Quant	XT pp512	XT first tok (ms)	XT tg (t/s)	Ti pp512	Ti first tok (ms)	Ti tg (t/s)
BF16	–	–	–	3933	167	47.0
Q8_0	4775	150	95.4	4971	139	81.2
Q6_K	4035	170	115.7	4141	136	98.6
Q5_K_M	4484	150	120.2	4572	130	108.1
Q4_K_M	4482	153	126.6	4653	128	119.0
Q4_K_S	4552	144	129.5	4802	128	124.3
Q4_0	4602	149	130.7	5033	121	128.5
IQ4_XS	4675	144	136.5	5035	122	127.9
Q3_K_L	4109	152	127.7	4448	131	118.2
Q3_K_M	4118	150	131.1	4441	129	123.3
Q3_K_S	3905	154	132.8	4206	131	123.8

Observations that shaped later decisions:

- KLD orders the quants cleanly; MMAU between Q8_0 and IQ4_XS (71.4–72.8) is inside noise, and only the Q3 family drops below the PyTorch reference. We therefore use KLD for ranking and MMAU as a sanity check.
- Q4_K_M's prefill (about 4.5–4.7k t/s) is the number to beat; the llama.cpp INT8 MMQ path tops out near 36–40 TOPS on this card.
- Mixed-precision storage is cheap: the 1.27 GB BF16 token-embedding/head tensor alone costs about 1 ms per decoded token (Section 7).

3 Audio front-end fix and ROCm 10.1

Audio. On stock llama.cpp the BF16 GGUF scores 70.2 on MMAU against 72.1 for PyTorch. Three differences in the mtmd audio path were found and fixed as *opt-in* GGUF keys (default off, so other models behave as upstream): `clip.audio.no_boundary_tokens` (Ossicle never saw `<|audio_start|>`/`<|audio_end|>`; ≈+1.2 pp), `clip.audio.polyphase_resample` (Kaiser polyphase like `scipy.signal.resample_poly` instead of linear; ≈+0.7 pp) and `clip.audio.exact_frame_count` (`ceil(n/hop)` mel frames as `WhisperFeatureExtractor`; ≈+0.3 pp). Patched BF16 reaches 71.8 (976/1000 answers identical to PyTorch). As a transfer check, the same two applicable keys lifted Qwen3-Omni-30B-A3B (Q4_K_M) from 78.9 to 80.0 MMAU (+1.10±0.46 pp paired, 16 up/5 down).

ROCm. On ROCm 7.2.0, Q8_0 and IQ4_XS (pp512 ≈1,100–1,300) and short-batch Q4_0 had slow prefill; ROCm 10.1.0 fixes it (Q8_0 pp512 1,123 → 4,775) at the price of 1–3% slower generation. All later work uses 10.1.0.

4 Int4 WMMA microbenchmarks

RDNA3 exposes `v_wmma_i32_16x16x16_iu4` at *twice* the rate of the iu8 variant. A pure-WMMA microbenchmark sustains 182 TOPS (190 on paper; about 195 at the 2.28 GHz this card holds at its power cap).

A standalone kernel was developed through 27 successive variants (`kernel/q4k_iu4_v2` … `q4s_iu4_v27`), always verified against a CPU reference (relative error 4.5×10^{-4}). The format: symmetric int4 weights (signed codes, no zero point) with one integer sub-scale per 32/64/128 K-values, multiplied by int4 activations.

Table 3: Standalone int4 GEMM throughput after warm-up (FFN 9216 × 2560 at $N = 512$; down 2560 × 9216 at $N = 2048$).

Sub-scale per	FFN N=512	FFN N=2048	down N=2048	extra KLD vs per-32
32 K-values	125 TOPS	128	124	–
64	142	144	143	+0.011
128	**149**	**149**	**152**	+0.015

That is 78% of the sustained theoretical peak and 83% of the best pure-WMMA loop. Where the rest goes: fragment loads ≈8–10%, integer scaling ≈5%, loop structure ≈4%. At llama.cpp's own reference shape (Q4_K, M=4096, N=512, K=14336) the pipeline "fused Hadamard rotation + quantise (0.04 ms) + GEMM (0.43 ms)" takes 0.47 ms (128 TOPS end-to-end) against 1.52 ms (39.6 TFLOPS in `test-backend-ops`) for the existing INT8 MMQ, i.e. about 3.2× on the matmul.

What got there: operand-ready weight repacking; scalar buffer-load addressing; 24-bit integer multiply-adds (inline asm); 8+ independent WMMA chains with scheduler barriers; chaining the accumulator through a whole scale unit (one multiply-add per unit); arranging a block's waves along the token dimension (1×8 waves so the weight tile is shared through cache); and a fused one-pass rotate+quantise+pack kernel (HadaCore idea, own RDNA3 implementation).

Benchmark pitfall. With only ∼10 ms of launches the GPU never reaches full clocks and a kernel looks about 1.5× slower (71 vs 110 TOPS for the same kernel). Warm up for at least 1 s of load. The same effect is why the `llama-bench` medians drop the first sample.

Dead ends in the microbenchmark phase.

- **FP4 checkpoints.** E2M1 needs 5 bits once doubled, so it cannot go through one int4 pass exactly. Re-fitting NVFP4/MXFP4 weights onto a uniform int4 grid cost about +0.07 KLD (0.096 native → 0.16–0.19). Plain symmetric int4 from a BF16 source is as accurate as FP4 (0.082 vs 0.098).
- **Sparsity skipping.** A wave-uniform group-skip loop is exact (62 → 98 TOPS at 75% skipped) but real activations give almost nothing to skip: all-zero 16-token×32-value tiles are 0–0.3% lossless and 2–6% even under aggressive thresholds (`int4/sparsity_probe*.py`).

5 The rotated-INT4 format

5.1 Rotation

Four-bit *activations* are the quality risk: transformer activations have outlier channels. We rotate with a block-Hadamard transform. For a linear layer $y = \mathbf{W}\mathbf{x}$ with input dimension K (multiple of 256), define per 256-block

$$\mathbf{R} = \tfrac{1}{16} H_{256}\, D, \qquad D = \mathrm{diag}(s_j), \quad s_j = -1 \text{ if } \big((j \cdot 2654435761) \bmod 2^{32}\big) \gg 31, \text{ else } +1,$$

where H_{256} is the Sylvester Hadamard matrix. $\mathbf{R}$ is orthogonal, so $\mathbf{W}' = \mathbf{W}\mathbf{R}^\top$ (applied blockwise along K) and $\mathbf{x}' = \mathbf{R}\mathbf{x}$ give $\mathbf{W}'\mathbf{x}' = \mathbf{W}\mathbf{x}$ exactly. The weights are rotated *offline* (`scripts/rotate_quantize.py`); activations are rotated *online* in the backend. The sign pattern is a hash so the C++ side and the converter agree without storing it. Rotation Gaussianises both operands, which is what makes 4-bit codes viable.

5.2 GPTQ on the rotated weights

The initial files used round-to-nearest (RTN) with $|\max|/7$ scales and codes in $[-7, 7]$. The final files use GPTQ (`scripts/gptq_rotate.py`):

1. Load the Ossicle LM in transformers (from `stage_lm` and the `src/` safetensors), BF16 on GPU.
2. Register a forward pre-hook on each of the 200 target linears; for the rotated input $\mathbf{x}'$ (in llama.cpp column order, including the out-projection head re-order) accumulate $H = \sum \mathbf{x}'^\top \mathbf{x}'$ in fp32 on the CPU. Calibration: 128 sequences × 512 tokens of WikiText-2 *train*, batches of 8.
3. For each tensor, GPTQ with Cholesky-inverse error feedback (damping 0.01 of the mean diagonal, column blocks of 128), codes in $[-8, 7]$, one fp16 scale per group of 32 columns. Each group's scale is chosen on the error-compensated weights by an MSE search over 26 candidates $\{0.55, \ldots, 1.05\} \cdot \max|w|/7$, rounded to fp16.
4. Pack as ordinary **Q4_0 blocks** (fp16 scale + 16 bytes: element j low nibble, j+16 high nibble) in a safetensors file keyed by GGUF tensor name. No new GGUF type is introduced.
5. `rotate_quantize.py --blocks` rebuilds the GGUF from BF16, re-rotating each tensor and *asserting the dequantised blocks are within 0.25 relative error of it* (a wrong row/column order shows up as ≈1.0).

GPTQ runs end-to-end in about four minutes (Hessians + 200 tensors; the quantisation loop itself ≈106 s) and about 15 GB of RAM. Mean relative weight error: 0.1071 (group 32), 0.1179 (group 64). A group-128 run died with ENOSPC (see Section 13) and was dropped.

The token embedding/output head is requantised separately: Q6_K (via `ggml_quantize_chunk`) or Q8_0. The GGUF gains two keys, `ossicle.int4_rotation_block`=256 and `ossicle.int4_scale_group`; the loader sets `GGML_INT4=3` automatically when the first is present.

5.3 How much does each ingredient buy?

Because iterating on the real runtime is slow, a Hugging Face simulation (`int4/w4a4_sim2.py`; Qwen3.5-4B, 24 chunks of 512 tokens, fake-quantised linears with exactly the rotation, scale-group and activation-scale logic of the kernels) was used to find what recovers quality. Figure 1 gives the ladder; the simulation's absolute KLD differs from the real file by a few thousandths because it quantises in bf16 matmuls and uses a different text slice.

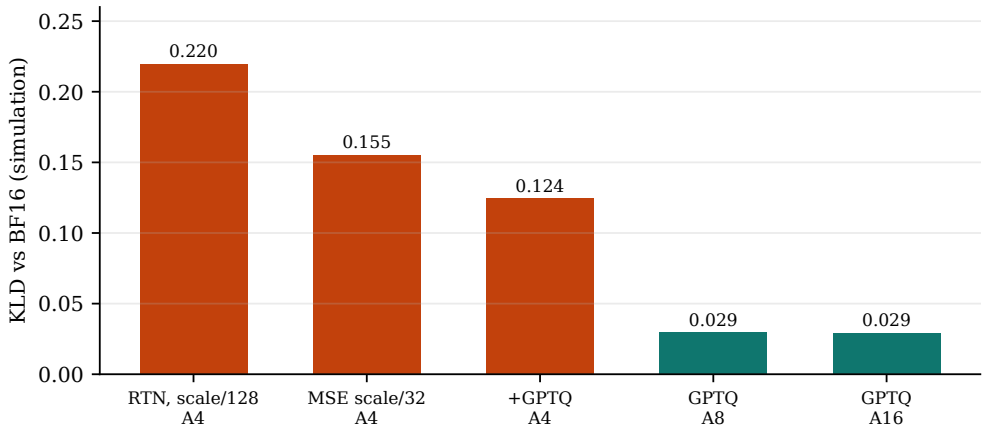


Figure 1: Simulated KLD ladder. The quality killer is the 4-bit *activation*, not the 4-bit weight: with GPTQ weights, 8-bit activations (0.029) are indistinguishable from 16-bit (0.029), while 4-bit activations cost +0.095.

Complete simulation results (KLD against fp16, same-top-1 in parentheses; fp16 PPL 11.560):

Configuration	KLD (top-1 %)
RTN, scale/128, A4	0.2195 (77.6)
RTN, scale/128, A16	0.1125 (84.5)
MSE, scale/128, A16	0.0807 (86.4)
MSE, scale/64, A16	0.0686 (87.1)
MSE, scale/32, A16	0.0584 (88.3)
MSE, scale/32, A4	0.1549 (81.5)
MSE, scale/32, A8	0.0588 (88.1)
MSE, scale/32, A16, 8-bit `down` weights	0.0477 (89.1)
MSE, scale/32, A16, 8-bit `down+v+o+ssm` weights	0.0294 (91.3)
GPTQ, scale/32, A16	0.0289 (92.2)
GPTQ, scale/32, A8	0.0294 (92.2)
GPTQ, scale/32, A4	0.1243 (83.3)
GPTQ, scale/32, A4 except A8 on `down+o+ssm`	0.0845 (86.1)

Three conclusions: (i) scale-per-32 beats per-64/128 by 0.01–0.02 KLD; (ii) GPTQ is worth about 0.03 KLD over MSE scales; (iii) A8 is free, A4 is not.

6 Runtime: the activation paths

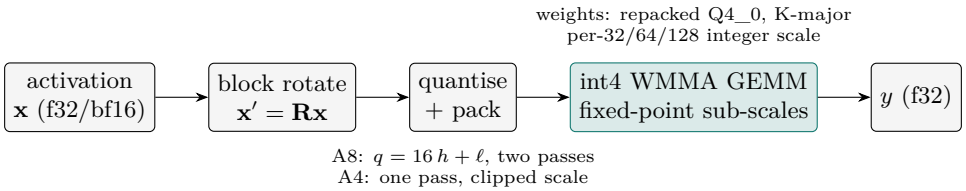


Figure 2: Prefill GEMM pipeline for a rotated tensor (rotate, quantise and pack are one fused kernel).

6.1 Eight-bit activations on int4 hardware (default prefill, "quality")

Every int8 code $q \in [-128, 127]$ is split as $q = 16h + \ell$ with $h \in [-8, 7]$ signed and $\ell \in [0, 15]$ unsigned. The GEMM runs the h pass, shifts the integer accumulator by 4 bits, runs the ℓ pass into the *same* accumulator, and then applies the integer weight sub-scale. Two int4 passes cost the same as one int8 pass, but the iu4 pipe is the one that is twice as fast, so the effective rate is 134 int4-TOPS = 67 int8-equivalent TOPS (about 74% of the iu4 ceiling) against 36–40 TOPS for the stock INT8 MMQ path. Integer weight scales use a fixed-point shift (SH8 = 12), and the final cross-unit accumulation is carried in float to avoid 24-bit overflow in the integer multiply-adds.

The weight scale group is detected at load time (`k_detect_gw`: GW $\in \{1, 2, 4\}$ means 32/64/128 columns per scale), so the same kernel serves group-32, 64 and 128 files; group 64 gives about +5% prefill for KLD 0.029 (0.0228 at group 32 with the Q8 head), group 128 would be about KLD 0.04.

6.2 Four-bit activations (the "fast" path)

A single int4 pass, with the activation scale per 256-block expressed as a multiplier $m \in \{1, \ldots, 16\}$ of 1/16 of a per-token reference scale: $m_b = \lceil 16\,\mathrm{clip} \cdot \mathrm{amax}_b / \mathrm{amax}_{\mathrm{token}} \rceil$ (this mirrors the simulation's `act_quant`). Weight scales use SH = 10. The **clip** factor shrinks the quantiser range so rare outliers saturate instead of stretching the scale:

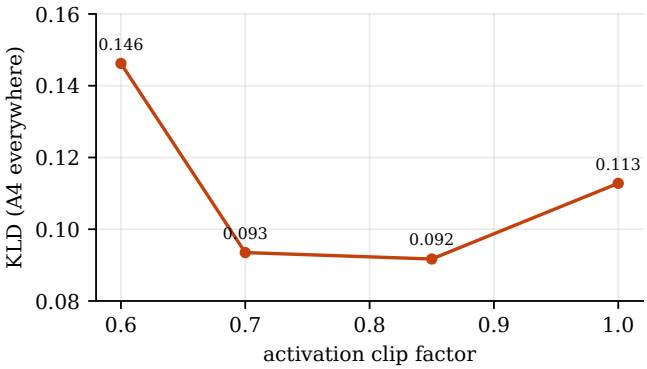


Figure 3: Effect of the 4-bit activation clip (all tensors A4; KLD vs BF16). The default 0.85 reduced KLD from 0.113 to 0.092 at no cost in speed; 0.6 is too aggressive.

6.3 Choosing activation width per tensor kind

Environment variables select which tensors take the 4-bit path; everything else stays at 8 bit.

Table 4: Control surface of the INT4 backend.

Variable	Meaning
`GGML_INT4=1/2/3`	1: rotation only; 2: 4-bit activations everywhere; 3: 8-bit activations (auto-set by the loader for rotated files)
`GGML_INT4_PREFILL`	`quality` (default): no A4; `balanced`: A4 on `attn_q.weight,attn_k,attn_v,attn_qkv,attn_gate,ffn_gate,ffn_up`; `fast`: A4 on `attn_,ffn_,ssm_`
`GGML_INT4_A4=<substrings>`	explicit list of tensor-name substrings that use A4 (overrides the preset)
`GGML_INT4_CLIP`	4-bit activation clip factor, default 0.85

Per-kind sensitivity (simulation with GPTQ weights; baseline KLD 0.0269; Figure 4) shows why one cannot rescue speed with a clever per-layer mix: the FFN has the FLOPs *and* the sensitivity.

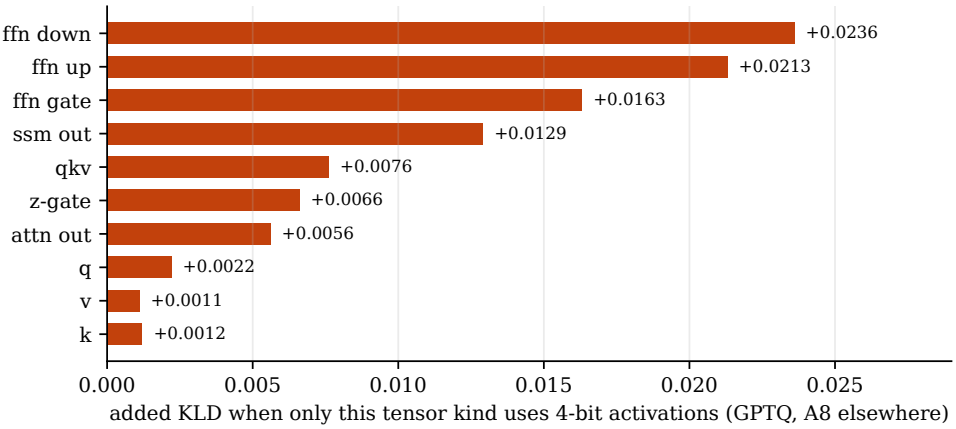


Figure 4: Added KLD when one tensor kind alone moves to 4-bit activations. FFN down/up/gate and the GDN out-projection dominate.

7 Decode: from 92 to 132 tokens/s

The first working INT4 path decoded at only 91.9 t/s with the older RTN file. Diagnosis and fixes:

- **Decode is launch-bound, not bandwidth-bound.** The GPU is about 64% busy with ∼3 µs gaps between ∼620 kernels per token; the matvec kernels already stream at the ∼733 GB/s ceiling. So the lever is fewer and leaner kernels, not faster matvecs.
- **Keep CUDA graphs and matmul fusion enabled.** The INT4 hook had disabled them; they are now skipped only for a rotated weight that cannot take the fused path (`ggml_cuda_int4_fused_ok`).
- **Fuse the rotation into Q8_1 quantisation** for batches ≤ 8 (`k_rot_q8_1`, called from `mul_mat_vec_q`): one kernel instead of rotate-then-quantise. Decode always uses 8-bit activations, so it carries no A4 penalty.
- **Shrink the head.** The 1.27 GB BF16 tied embedding/head cost about 1 ms per token alone. Q6_K costs +0.002 KLD and buys +6 t/s; Q8_0 is KLD-better (0.0228) but slower (126.6 t/s).

Result: 132.6 t/s (Q6_K head) / 126.6 t/s (Q8_0 head), against 131.6 t/s for Q4_K_M. All preset changes later in the work left tg128 within 130–132.

8 Results: Q4-quality at higher prefill

Median of 8 runs after the first; KLD on 24 chunks of WikiText-2 test; MMAU with the audio patch.

Table 5: Rotated-INT4 files vs Q4_K_M (RX 7900 XT, ROCm 10.1.0, 8-bit prefill activations).

Model	GB	pp512	pp2048	tg128	PPL vs BF16	KLD	top-1	MMAU
Q4_K_M	2.7	4,733	4,595	131.6	+3.3%	0.032	91%	72.2
rotq4-gptq (Q6_K head)	2.55	**5,571**	**5,399**	**132.6**	+1.9%	0.0246	92.2%	71.7
rotq4-gptq-q8head	2.70	5,622	5,402	126.6	+1.7%	0.0228	93.5%	72.0
older: rotq4g4 (RTN, A4)	3.3	8,041	7,615	91.9	+17.6%	0.197	81%	69.0

So the answer to "get it to Q4 quality" is positive: prefill +18% at that point, decode at par, and KLD *below* Q4_K_M's (0.023–0.025 vs 0.032), with MMAU inside noise of Q4_K_M and BF16. The group-64 variant with the Q8 head gave KLD 0.0293 (so group-32 stays the default). Note that 0.0246 above is from before the wave32 GDN kernel of Section 10; the same file measures 0.0252 after it (floating-point summation order changes; the difference is inside the ±0.0012 standard error).

9 Reaching 8k prefill

The target: pp512 ≈ 8,000 tokens/s with decode held at ∼132 t/s. The 8-bit GEMM pair of passes is itself close to its ceiling (Section 9.3), so the remaining levers were (a) use fewer GEMM bits per tensor, (b) speed up the non-GEMM parts (gated-delta-net recurrence first), (c) recover the quality of (a).

9.1 Per-kind A4 sweep

`scripts/sweep_a4.sh` runs, for each activation-width configuration of the *same* GGUF, KLD (24 chunks) and the median bench. Results (Figure 5 plots them against the standard quants):

Table 6: Prefill preset sweep on `ossicle-4b-gptq-g32-q6e.gguf`. Tokens/s are medians; "A4 on" lists the tensor kinds using single-pass 4-bit activations (clip 0.85); the rest are A8.

A4 on	pp512	pp2048	tg128	KLD	top-1 %
nothing (`quality`)	5,846	5,647	131.8	0.0252	92.5
q/k/v, qkv, z-gate, ffn gate	6,784	6,488	131.9	0.0519	89.3
+ ffn up (`balanced`)	7,257	6,935	131.5	0.0713	87.3
+ ffn down	7,857	7,504	131.3	0.0871	86.8
everything (`fast`)	**8,248**	7,797	131.9	0.0964	85.4

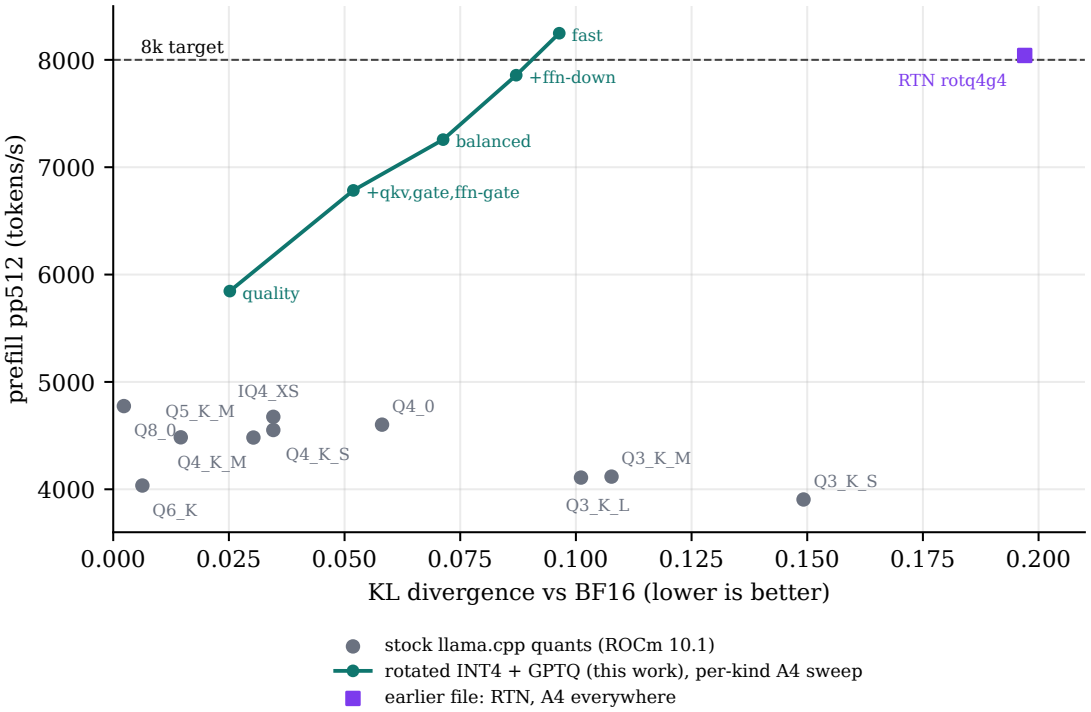


Figure 5: Prefill speed against fidelity. Stock quants cluster at 4.0–4.8k t/s; the rotated-INT4 sweep moves right along a roughly linear speed–KLD trade-off from 5.8k to 8.2k. (Stock KLD from the full-study table; INT4 points from the sweep above.)

The final confirmation run of `fast` on the committed build gave pp512 8,269 / pp2048 7,802 / tg128 131.7 (the sweep run measured 8,248 / 7,797 / 131.9; run-to-run variation is ∼0.3%). Likewise the `balanced` confirmation gave pp512 7,243 / pp2048 6,930 against the sweep's 7,257 / 6,935. We quote the final numbers in the abstract and the sweep numbers in this table; neither is a transcription error.

Table 7: Final presets, same file (`rotq4-gptq`, Q6_K head).

Preset	pp512	pp2048	tg128	PPL vs BF16	KLD	top-1	MMAU
`quality` (A8 everywhere)	5,846	5,647	131.8	+1.9%	0.0252	92.5%	71.7
`balanced`	7,243	6,930	131.1	–	0.071	87.3%	–
`fast` (A4 everywhere)	**8,269**	**7,802**	**131.7**	+7.4%	0.096	85.4%	71.6

Reading the trade-off. `fast` sits between Q4_0 (KLD 0.058) and Q3_K_L (0.101) on KLD at about twice the Q3 prefill rate. Its MMAU score (71.6) is indistinguishable from `quality` (71.7), but MMAU has ±1.4 pp noise and audio questions are dominated by the audio encoder; the KLD/PPL numbers are the more sensitive indicators and they do degrade. Four-bit activations carry about 10% relative noise per matmul (20 dB SNR); at 8k the KLD cannot be recovered without more bits.

9.2 Where the speed comes from

- **GEMM bit-width**: one pass instead of two for A4 tensors (the bulk of the 5,846 → 8,269 gain).
- **Activation clip 0.85**: quality only (KLD 0.113 → 0.092 in the clip experiment), no speed effect.
- **Wave32 gated-delta-net kernel**: +5% prefill (5,571 → 5,846 at pp512), Section 10.

9.3 Tile shapes

The GEMM tile constants (MI=2, NJ=2, WAVES_N=8) were varied: (2,2,4), (2,2,16) and (1,2,8) all landed within 2% of each other. The prefill GEMM is therefore near its practical ceiling (about 74% of iu4 peak

at A8), and the rest of the prefill budget is no longer the GEMM alone: at `fast`, a 512-token pass takes ≈62 ms of which gated-delta-net is 22%, flash attention 3–7%, and rotate+quantise ≈3%.

10 Gated-delta-net: what worked and what did not

The recurrence per head is $S_t = a_t\, S_{t-1} + k_t\, \delta_t^\top$ with $\delta_t = \beta_t\,(v_t - S_{t-1}^\top k_t)$ and output $o_t = S_t^\top q_t$; state $S \in \mathbb{R}^{128\times128}$ per head, 24 GDN layers, 32 value heads. It is sequential in t, and at pp512 it takes 0.54 ms per layer per 512 tokens (22% of a `fast` pass).

10.1 Kept: two lanes per state column (wave32)

`gated_delta_net_cols` (HIP only, S_v=128, scalar gate, non-KDA): each state column is owned by *two* lanes holding 64 state registers each; one `__shfl_xor(…,16)` per reduction; k/q double-buffered in wave-private LDS; the next token's v, β, g prefetched. Grid $(H, n_{\text{seqs}}, 2)$, block $(32, 4)$. Gain: +5% prefill (pp512 5,571 → 5,846), KLD unchanged within error. The path that led here:

- Software pipelining of the original kernel's loads: no gain.
- One lane per column: 256 VGPRs, spilled. LDS-staged variant: worse. *Two* lanes per column (64 state registers each): fixed it.
- Prefetching v, β, g in the new kernel: no measurable gain.

10.2 First attempt, reverted: chunked WY form without matrix instructions

The chunked form turns the recurrence into matrix products per chunk of C tokens: build the strictly lower-triangular interaction L, invert $(I + L)$, form $\eta = U - WS_0$, produce the chunk's outputs, and update the state. A scalar-code prep and scan kernel were *correct* (KLD 0.0249 against 0.0252) but slower (3,401–5,307 against 5,846 tokens/s at pp512): without matrix instructions the chunk algebra is bound by LDS latency and register pressure. That work was reverted and saved as `kernel/gated_delta_net_chunked_wip.cu`.

10.3 Kept: chunked WY form on WMMA (Section 11)

The rewrite on `v_wmma_f32_16x16x16_f16` is described in Section 11; the per-layer cost of the op fell from 0.46 ms to 0.14 ms per 512 tokens (13% → 4% of a pass). The lesson of the first attempt carried over: on RDNA3 the code that decides the speed is the *ISA*, not the algebra — twice the slowdown came from the compiler turning an unrolled `if (tok < n) x = load(...)` into a branch with a `vmcnt(0)` wait per element, which serialises every global load.

11 Final round: one copy of the weights, WMMA gated-delta-net and attention, fusion, decode, MTP

This section supersedes the speed tables of Sections 10–12 written before it (the model, the quantisation and the quality numbers are unchanged). All speeds: median of 8 `llama-bench` runs after one discarded, RX 7900 XT.

11.1 VRAM: 2× → 1×

The prefill kernel's repacked weight layout (nibbles in WMMA operand order plus fixed-point sub-scales) has *exactly* the byte size of the Q4_0 tensor. Each rotated weight is therefore converted in place the first time a graph uses it, through a temporary copy of one tensor at a time and before any CUDA graph is captured; decode got its own matvec (`k_mv`) reading that layout directly, and the GEMM accepts any contiguous batch shape. Peak VRAM for pp512+tg: 5,511 → 3,413 MiB (Q4_K_M: 3,652). Prefill unchanged, decode +4%, KLD bit-identical in prefill. This also exposed that the earlier `fast` KLD was understated (Caveats).

11.2 Prefill

	quality		fast	
step	pp512	pp2048	pp512	pp2048
start of this round (in-place weights)	5,836	5,644	8,212	7,773
chunked WMMA gated-delta-net	6,369	6,106	9,208	8,721
shared activation packing, SWIGLU / SILU·mul inside the pack kernel, tiled conv concat	6,744	6,489	10,090	9,501
WMMA flash attention (head 256), residual add in the GEMM epilogue, skinny bf16 gate kernel	6,945	6,885	10,457	10,333
gate epilogue, paired q/k L2 norm, 128-thread head norms	7,082	6,991	10,895	10,570
final (after the decode work)	**7,109**	**6,996**	**10,932**	**10,599**

Perplexity, KLD (0.0250, +2.0%) and MMAU (71.7–71.9) did not move beyond noise at any step; the fusions are bit-identical to the unfused path, the GDN and attention kernels differ at the f16 level (below).

Chunked GDN on WMMA. A *prep* kernel (parallel over chunk×head) forms $A = \mathrm{tril}(\beta_j e^{g_j - g_i} k_j \cdot k_i)$ and $P = \mathrm{tril}(e^{g_t - g_j} q_t \cdot k_j)$ with f16 WMMA, solves $(I + A)X = [\beta v \,|\, \beta e^{g} k]$ in 16-row panels (WMMA for the off-diagonal updates, f32 for the 16×16 diagonal solves) and stores U, W, Q_g, K_d, P; a *scan* kernel (sequential over chunks, parallel over heads × 16 state columns) keeps the f32 state in WMMA accumulators and does $\delta = U - WS$, $o = Q_g S + P\delta$, $S \leftarrow e^{g_C} S + K_d^{\top}\delta$. 0.46 ms → 0.14 ms per layer per 512 tokens. Accuracy against an f64 recurrence on captured real operands: $1.6\text{–}2.5 \cdot 10^{-4}$ relative RMS per layer (the per-token kernel: $4.5 \cdot 10^{-7}$). Because the 4/8-bit activation quantisers amplify any perturbation, final logits differ from the per-token kernel's by KLD 0.002 (97% same top-1), yet KLD against BF16 is unchanged. A residual-bit variant (`GGML_GDN_CHUNK=2`) did not help. Optimisation story: the first version took 167 µs per call; ISA inspection showed `s_waitcnt vmcnt(0)` after every load because loads sunk into predicated branches, an f32 triangular solve limited by LDS latency, and SGPR spills. The panel scheme with branch-free preloads reached 93 µs; the scan 42 µs.

WMMA flash attention for head size 256. The generic tile kernel ran at ∼14 TFLOPs and was 12.5% of a `fast` pp2048 pass. Enabling upstream's own WMMA kernel for head 256 on RDNA3 gives wrong results (errors $\sim 10^{-2}$; it is excluded upstream), so we wrote one (`fattn-rdna3.cu`): a block owns 64 rows = tokens×GQA heads sharing a K/V head, 8 waves (the head dimension split over wave pairs, halving the O accumulators), Q in LDS, K and $V^{\top}$ tiles of 32 positions through one LDS buffer with conflict-free transposed V writes, K/V/mask prefetched into registers, tiles fully hidden by the mask skipped, heaviest causal blocks scheduled first. 25.5 ms → 12.0 ms per pp2048 pass; all 2,920 `FLASH_ATTN_EXT` tests pass.

Fusion. At pp2048 CUDA graphs cannot be reused (K/V length changes every ubatch), so every launch costs ∼3.3 µs of idle GPU. Folded away: the three memsets per GEMM; the re-pack of activations shared by sibling matmuls (qkv+z, q/k/v, gate/up); SWIGLU / SILU·mul feeding a GEMM (inside the pack kernel); the residual ADD (GEMM epilogue); GDN alpha/beta (convert + hipBLASLt + convert → one skinny bf16 WMMA kernel with the sigmoid / softplus·A epilogue); the q/k L2 norms (paired launch); the conv concat (tiled LDS transpose, 1.8 ms → 0.6 ms).

11.3 Decode: 138 → 174 tokens/s

A decode token needs ≈2.0 GB of body weights plus the 0.52 GB Q6_K head: 3.4 ms at the 750 GB/s streaming ceiling. The profile showed 847 kernels per token with the GPU busy only 64% of the time (a GDN layer: 26 kernels, 153 µs of work spread over 235 µs): the matvecs already ran at ∼92% of the ceiling, so the work was removing launches.

step	kernels/token	tg128
start	847	138.3
rotated activations shared by sibling matvecs; residual add in the matvec epilogue	732	143.3
GDN alpha/beta skinny bf16 matvec with gate epilogue (sigmoid; softplus·A)	708	147.1
RMS norm fused with the rotation + 8-bit quantisation (`k_rmsnorm_rot_q8x`); silu(z)·norm folded into the matvec rotation	620	152.3
10-wave matvec blocks (divides the 10 superblocks of K=2560)	620	155.0
GDN state read straight from the cache row (2 MB gather per layer skipped)	596	159.6
conv cluster: state gather + concat + cpy + `ssm_conv` + silu in one kernel	524	166.9
alpha+beta in one launch; q/k L2 norm folded into the GDN decode kernel	476	172.3
rotation + quantisation inside the matvec for single-consumer inputs	412	173.9

Decode-path KLD/PPL are unchanged (batch 1: 0.0232, +1.87%; batch 8: 0.0228, +1.78%; MMAU 71.7). Two bugs worth recording: fusion bookkeeping keyed by tensor addresses must be reset for every graph (the allocator reuses addresses; a stale entry turned into an assertion in the parallel server), and a fusion that executes a later node early is only safe when nothing that allocates temporary memory sits in between (checked per pattern). What remains of a 5.7 ms token: matvecs 3.0 ms, head 0.66 ms (at the ceiling), ∼0.5 ms rotate/norm, ∼1 ms launch gaps.

11.4 Stock Qwen3.5-4B on the same recipe

`Qwen/Qwen3.5-4B` (post-trained release, no audio) through `gptq_rotate.py --group 32` (now reading the original checkpoint layout) and `rotate_quantize.py --embd q6_k`: 2.55 GB, mean relative weight error 0.107 (Ossicle: 0.107). Against its own BF16 GGUF (PPL 8.84):

	pp512	pp2048	tg128	PPL	KLD	top-1
`quality`	7,126	7,008	173.9	+1.9%	0.0241	92.7%
`fast`	10,981	10,592	173.8	+8.7%	0.0969	86.1%

The recipe is not specific to Ossicle: same KLD, same cost of 4-bit activations, same speed.

11.5 Multi-token prediction

Qwen3.5 checkpoints carry a one-layer MTP head (`mtp.*`); llama.cpp drives it as a draft (`--spec-type draft-mtp`) with a separate head GGUF (`convert_hf_to_gguf.py --mtp`). The Ossicle checkpoint had dropped those tensors; the stock head works on it. The draft step is dominated by the 248k-row head, so its width matters (stock model, 2 drafts: Q8_0 head 195, Q6_K 207, Q4_K 213 tokens/s with unchanged acceptance); the shipped head file (Q8_0 layer, Q4_K embedding/output) is 0.50 GB.

`llama-server`, greedy, 4×192 tokens	plain	1 draft	**2 drafts**	3 drafts	acceptance (2)
Ossicle-4B + stock MTP head	168.6	218.1	**232.5**	229.5	73%
Stock Qwen3.5-4B	168.5	215.6	**218.8**	217.0	64%

Output was identical to plain greedy decoding (4×160 tokens). Two drafts is the optimum because a draft step costs ∼1.5 ms against a 5.8 ms target token and a verification batch of 3 costs 1.4× a single token (the conv-state fusion was extended to the rollback-slot copies of the speculative graph to keep it cheap). Not done: rotated INT4 weights for the MTP layer (GPTQ needs hidden-state calibration), cheaper head via candidate shortlisting, tree drafting.

12 Negative and neutral results (consolidated)

Idea	Outcome
RTN rotated int4 + A4 (first integrated file)	KLD 0.197–0.220; usable speed (8,041 pp512) but PPL +17.6%; superseded.
Wider weight scale groups (64/128)	+5% prefill for +0.005–0.015 KLD; group 32 kept as default.
NVFP4/MXFP4 → uniform int4	+0.07 KLD, no gain over BF16→int4.
Sparsity skipping in the GEMM	Exact and fast on synthetic sparsity; real tiles are 0–6% skippable.
Tile-shape retuning (MI,NJ,waves)	Flat within 2%.
Per-layer A4/A8 mix without per-kind logic	FFN carries both FLOPs and sensitivity; no mix recovers 8k at A8 quality.
GDN software pipelining; LDS-staged cols; v/β/g prefetch	No gain or worse.
Chunked WY GDN (scalar code)	Correct but 9–42% slower than recurrent (above).
Clip 0.6 for A4	KLD 0.146, worse than no clip (0.113); 0.7: 0.093; 0.85 chosen (0.092).

13 Failures and mishaps during the run

- **Disk exhaustion.** Both filesystems ran full. `/mnt/data` was at 1.4 GB free, so GPTQ safetensors were written to `/home/svt/ossicle-tmp`; intermediates and old GGUFs were deleted as needed; the group-128 GPTQ run failed with ENOSPC and was dropped.
- `__builtin_amdgcn_wmma_*` requires constant flags; a runtime `pass == 0` flag failed to compile and was replaced by separate if/else branches.
- A calibration file deleted while a simulation was starting broke one sweep; it was re-run on `wiki.train.raw`.
- `llvm-objdump --offloading` scattered extracted bundle files into the build `bin` directory; removed with a targeted `rm`.
- A `pkill -f` pattern matched and killed the controlling shell; replaced by explicit PIDs. A relative-glob `rm` was blocked by the safety check and a fresh directory was used instead.
- The harness blocked `sleep` chained to `tail`; polling loops of `grep -q` with short sleeps were used instead.

14 Caveats and limitations

- **RDNA3 only** (gfx1100 family, ROCm). The GGUFs are *not* ordinary Q4_0 files: any other build or backend decodes the rotated codes as if they were unrotated and produces garbage. They only work with the `ossicle` branch.
- **Detection heuristic:** any `blk.*` Q4_0 tensor with $K \bmod 256 = 0$ is treated as rotated when `ossicle.int4_rotation_block` is present.
- **VRAM:** each rotated weight is converted *in place* the first time a graph uses it (the repacked layout has exactly the byte size of the Q4_0 tensor), so weights cost 1× the file (peak 3.36 GB for pp512+tg against 3.65 GB for Q4_K_M). The converted tensors are no longer valid Q4_0; `GGML_INT4_INPLACE=0` restores the older two-copy layout (5.5 GB). Untested: multi-GPU, unloading and reloading a model in one process, partial offload, and more than one sequence in the speculative graphs beyond a smoke test.
- **Integer headroom:** the 24-bit integer multiply-adds assume activation sums that fit 24 bits. True for real data with about 8× margin at 8-bit; not guaranteed for adversarial inputs.
- **Calibration is text-only** (WikiText-2 train); the audio path is not represented, and MMAU

(±1.4 pp) is too coarse to detect a loss of the size KLD shows.

- **Single GPU, no MoE, no batched matmul;** one run per MMAU configuration; KLD from 24 chunks.
- **Corrected `fast` KLD:** earlier revisions reported 0.0964. Those runs used 4-sequence perplexity batches in which the GDN out-projection (3-D activations) silently fell back to the 8-bit path; the kernels now accept any contiguous batch shape and the all-4-bit value is 0.101–0.105 (0.0917 in the older clip experiment was the same artefact).
- **Licence:** the HF repository's licence field is still `other`; set a real licence before making it public.
- The HF repo (`SILVERTHRONE/Ossicle-4B-GGUF`) and the GitHub fork are *private*.

15 Reproduction

Build the INT4 file.

```
# 1. BF16 GGUF from the safetensors
python scripts/convert_ossicle.py  ...                       # -> ossicle-4b-bf16.gguf

# 2. GPTQ on rotated weights (needs HF safetensors, ~15 GB RAM, ~4 min, writes ~2.5 GB)
python scripts/gptq_rotate.py --src stage_lm --out gptq_g32.safetensors --group 32 --calib 128

# 3. Rebuild the GGUF from BF16 with the GPTQ blocks; Q6_K head; per-tensor error check
python scripts/rotate_quantize.py ossicle-4b-bf16.gguf ossicle-4b-gptq-g32-q6e.gguf \
       --blocks gptq_g32.safetensors --embd q6_k
```

Run it.

```
GGML_INT4_PREFILL=fast llama-server -m rdna3/ossicle-4b-rotq4-gptq.gguf \
    --mmproj mmproj-ossicle-4b-f16.gguf --jinja -ngl 99          # drop the variable for the quality default
```

Measure it.

```
# KLD (24 chunks vs the BF16 base logits) + full bench for one configuration
scripts/measure_int4.sh <tag> <model.gguf> GGML_INT4=3 GGML_INT4_PREFILL=fast
#   = llama-perplexity -m M -f wiki.test.raw -c 512 -ngl 99 --chunks 24 \
#                      --kl-divergence-base kld_base.bin --kl-divergence

# median of 8 runs (llama-bench -p 512,2048 -n 128 -r 9, first sample dropped)
scripts/bench_med.sh <model.gguf> GGML_INT4_PREFILL=fast

# per-kind A4 sweep
scripts/sweep_a4.sh <model.gguf> out.tsv "none:none" "fast:attn_,ffn_,ssm_" ...

# MMAU test-mini via llama-server (with the audio patch's mmproj)
scripts/run_mmau_int4.sh  [EXTRA=env]

# Simulation behind Figure 1 (HF transformers, needs GPU)
python int4/w4a4_sim2.py --calib 128 --configs "fp16" "wg=32,wm=gptq,a=8" "wg=32,wm=gptq,a=4" ...
```

16 Artefacts

- **Fork:** `github.com/SILVERTHRONE32/llama.cpp-ossicle`, branch `ossicle`, head `72ec3b93e`. Stack on top of upstream `f2b52a87e`: `0fc5f77a2` (audio keys), `22ca9a167` (opt-in INT4 WMMA prefill), `fe6ca0637` (8-bit activations), `2b78d7055`, `2d6f34eee`, `1fcc55e87` (presets, clip, wave32 GDN), `13ebf210c` (single-copy weights, decode matvec), `66bd3df08` / `99c913a0f` (WMMA GDN), `526218595`, `7826d2611`, `d564736b9` (activation sharing, GLU in the pack kernel, tiled concat), `d538672cb` (WMMA attention), the residual / skinny-gate / L2 commits, and the decode series ending in `72ec3b93e` (conv cluster incl. speculative graph).
- **HF repo (private):** `SILVERTHRONE/Ossicle-4B-GGUF`: `rdna3/ossicle-4b-rotq4-gptq.gguf` (2.55 GB), `rdna3/ossicle-4b-rotq4-gptq-q8head.gguf` (2.70 GB), `experimental/ossicle-4b-rotq4g4.gguf` (older RTN), the ten standard quants, mmproj, model card, patches (`llama.cpp-ossicle-audio.patch`, `llama.cpp-ossicle-int4.patch`), scripts, `int4/w4a4_sim2.py`, the chunked GDN WIP kernel, `rdna3/qwen35-4b-rotq4-gptq.gguf` (stock Qwen3.5-4B, 2.55 GB) and `rdna3/mtp-qwen35-4b-head-q4_k.gguf` (MTP head, 0.50 GB).

- **Local:** `/mnt/data/projects/ossicle-gguf` (scripts, logs in `work/`, kernels in `kernel/`, simulations in `int4/`), main model `/home/svt/ossicle-tmp/ossicle-4b-gptq-g32-q6e.gguf`.

17 Next steps

1. **Default preset.** Decide whether `fast` should be the default for rotated files, or keep `quality` and document `fast` as opt-in (current state).
2. **Decode.** What is left is ∼1 ms of launch gaps: fusing the attention-layer chain (q/k norm, rope, KV write), a rotation prologue for the remaining shared inputs, and a cheaper head. MTP: INT4 weights for the draft layer, a draft head shared with the target, tree drafting.
3. **Prefill.** GEMM is 79% of a pass at ∼74% of the int4 WMMA ceiling; the GDN prep kernel is limited to one block per CU by LDS (a 32-token chunk variant fits two).
4. **Audio-aware calibration** for GPTQ (mix speech/sound/music features into the Hessian text), and a larger MMAU sample or multiple seeds to resolve differences below ∼2 pp.
5. Set a licence and decide on public release of the HF repository.